

Ethical and Legal Considerations

Avoiding Leading Questions

Final Year Project: COSC023W & 6CSEF002W

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Consider the following scenario:

- You completed the implementation of a mobile app that was part of your final year project.
- You want to gather some feedback from your friend (or colleague), Anne.
- This is what you say to Anne:

Thank you so much, Anne, for agreeing to participate in this research. I'm so excited to get feedback on this app for my final year project. I have worked very hard on it, I don't have much time left until submission and I know you're going to love it."

Then, imagine you conclude your research (or evaluation) session by asking Anne if there was anything she did not like about the app.

Do you see any problem?

- Your job is to gather user feedback that isn't influenced by your own expectations.
- Your job is to listen (not to lead/influence).

Avoid Leading Questions

- Leading questions lead to responses that are not particularly true or useful.
- **Strive to remain neutral and ask open questions.**
- **Consider how to word questions to get richer, non-leading feedback.**

Q1

- *Would you rather use the old version or this improved version of the website?*

- ~~Would you rather use the old version or this improved version of the website?~~
- By calling one version “improved,” you are already tricking participants’ brains into thinking that one is better than the other. It’s probably better to just call them Version A and Version B, or something along these lines.

Q2

- *What did you expect would happen when you pressed that button?*

- *What did you expect would happen when you pressed that button?*
- This is a good question, especially when the user has already pressed the button so you are not suggesting they do so.
- This question taps into the user's mental model for how the product/system/prototype works.

Q3

- *How easy was it to find the pricing page?*

- ~~How easy was it to find the pricing page?~~
- Try not to bias your questions by suggesting a specific response. Make sure all your questions are as objective as possible. A good way to reframe this could be:
- *How easy or difficult was it to find the pricing page?*

Q4

- *How would you normally perform this task, without this tool?*

- *How would you normally perform this task, without this tool?*
- This is a very good question. It is also a very useful one because it gives you further context and important information about the problem(s) you are trying to solve with the product.

Q5

- *Do you find this feature frustrating to use?*

- ~~Do you find this feature frustrating to use?~~
- As a researcher, you can conclude that a feature is frustrating through your own data or by the user explicitly saying so. However, by asking this question directly, users are likely to think too hard about it and you might not get genuine answers.

Q6

- *Would you use this product if it were in your house?*

- ~~Would you use this product if it were in your house?~~
- Most people would answer “yes,” and therefore this question doesn’t give you a lot of useful information. Try to get at this answer using a different way of questioning. People really are not good at predicting the future, so focus on their past experiences and pain points.

Q7

- *What are some advantages and disadvantages of these designs?*

- *What are some advantages and disadvantages of these designs?*
- This is a good question.

What Makes a Question Leading

- § Do not rephrase in our own words.
- § Do not suggest an answer.
- § Do not name an interface element.
- § Do not assume you know what the user is feeling.

